Online, it costs about ₹499 to win a daily saver, and only 24 in 100 are still saving a year later — so each saver kept costs ₹2,067.

HOW AN APP WINS A DAILY SAVER, AND WHAT IT COSTS



₹2,067

for each saver still saving after a year

and he earns back only ₹243 in his first 3 years: the app never recovers what it paid

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Groww
₹796–1,374 a customer, with 83% coming free

Finance-app installs
₹100–300 each

Jar, Stable Money
₹249 a saver, only if half of sign-ups save

SBI's ₹250 daily SIP
lost 35.6% of FY26's new savers within the year

Online this saver is cheap to reach but costly to keep, and in three years he does not earn back what the app paid for him. ₹499 is our estimate: no firm publishes this cost for shopkeepers.

Sources: tables/distributions.csv, tables/story_unit.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

Our hypothesis: offline, a street agent can win this saver for less (H1), keep him saving with a visit every 2–3 days (H2), and earn enough from that relationship to pay for himself (H3).

H1

Win him for less

₹240 a saver

₹20,000 a month ÷ 83 sign-ups a month

online: ₹499

H2

Keep him saving with the visit

43+ of 100

still saving after a year: where a salaried agent breaks even

online: 24 of 100

H3

Earn enough to pay for him

117%

of his salary paid by his savers over 3 years, at 55 in 100 still saving

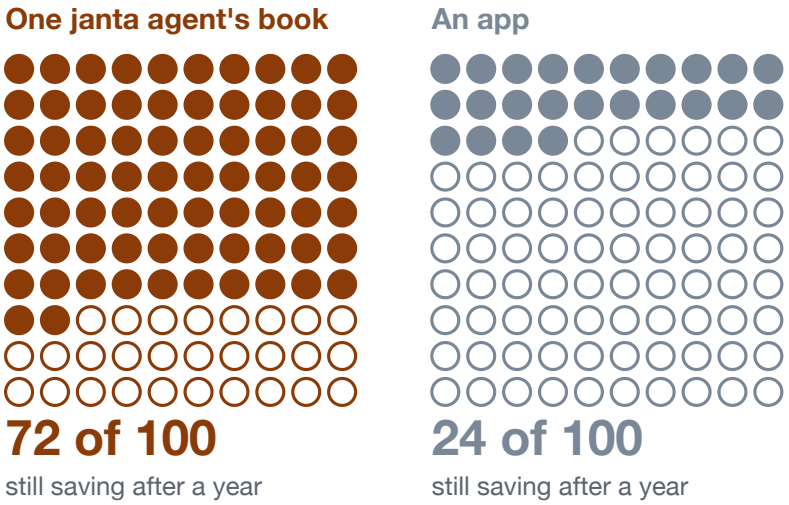
online: never earns back its cost

Each part can fail on its own. Pages 3–6 give the evidence for H1 and H2; pages 7–11 stress-test H3; page 12 tests all three.

Sources: tables/scn_inputs.csv, tables/scn_retention.csv, tables/story_unit.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

Our customer already saves every day, in cash, with an agent he trusts — and in the one agent's book we have seen, about 72 in 100 are still saving a year later.

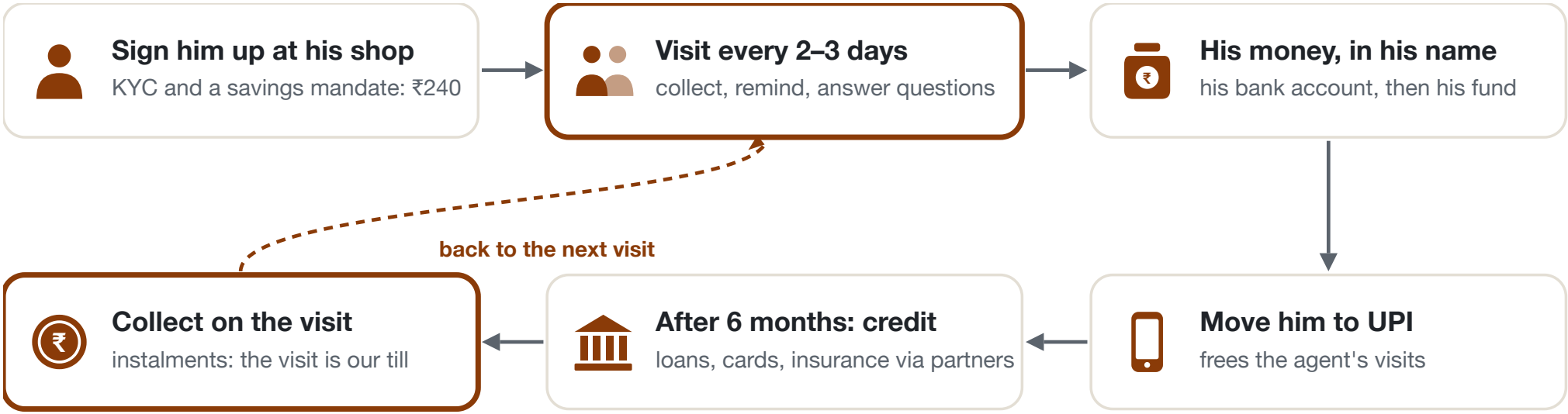
- **Saves ₹200–500 a day, in cash, with a janta agent**
- **9–10 in 10 have UPI, yet 90+ of every ₹100 is cash: “habit”**
- **Asks his agent about loans and insurance**
- **6–10 join and 6–10 leave a month on a book of 200–400**



The habit and the trust already exist, and his customers ask him for loans and insurance — but this is one agent's account of his own long-standing book, not a group of new savers we have measured.

Sources: research/interview_arvinder_2026-10-15.csv, tables/story_unit.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

So we build the business around that visit: sign him up at his shop, visit every 2–3 days, grow a fund in his name, move him to UPI, and after 6 months offer loans, cards and insurance.



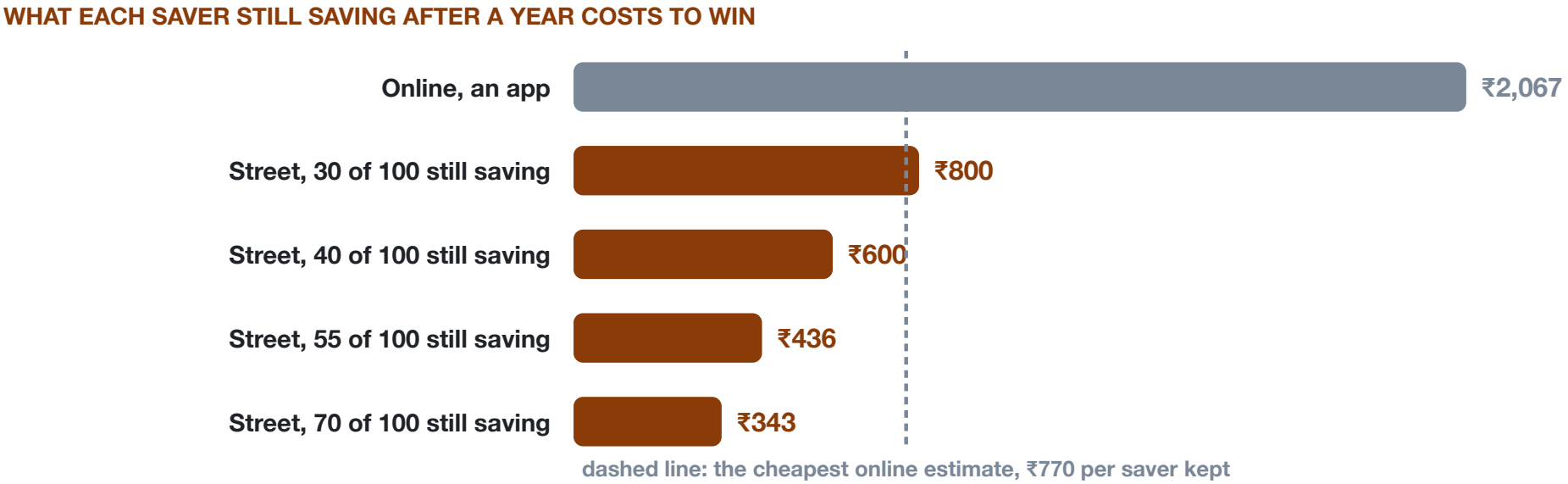
Behind every agent: tele-sales and an AI agent

missed-debit follow-ups, the switch to UPI, loan pre-checks; their cost is not yet in these numbers

One person carries the relationship from sign-up to loan. The stress test that follows counts only the street agent's pay — not tele-sales, the AI agent or the office.

Sources: tables/scn_inputs.csv, tables/story_paytm.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

On a ₹20,000 salary, an agent signing up 1,000 savers a year wins each for ₹240 — so even if only 30 in 100 keep saving, each saver kept costs ₹800, less than half of online's ₹2,067.



Winning and keeping him is where the street is strongest (₹800 ÷ ₹2,067 = 0.39) — though at the cheapest end of the online estimate (₹186 ÷ 0.2415 = ₹770) the bear case is no cheaper.

Sources: tables/distributions.csv, tables/scn_inputs.csv, tables/scn_retention.csv, tables/story_unit.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

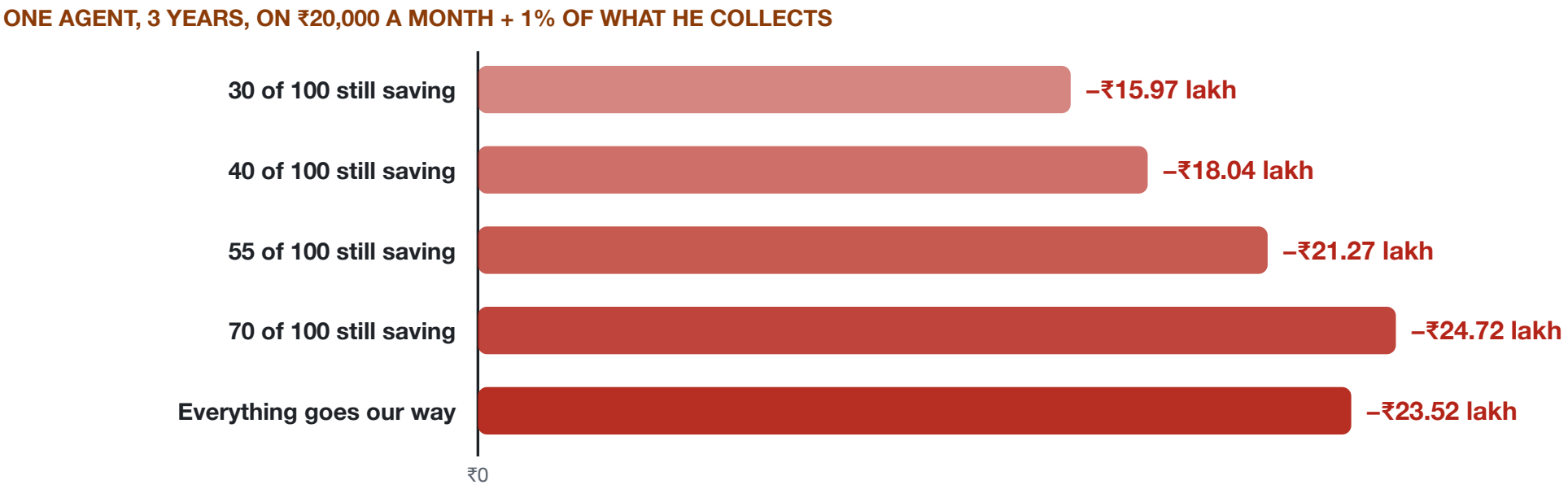
Paytm plays the same street game, and we can win the customer far more cheaply — but Paytm earns several times more from each one, so what it costs us to serve him must stay low.

	Paytm	Us, salaried street agent	Who is ahead
ROUND 1 Win him	up to ~₹5,000 a device (an upper bound)	**₹240 a saver**	✓ Us, up to 20.8× cheaper
ROUND 2 Keep him	a box on the counter	**the visit; we need 43+ of 100 still saving**	? Open: the pilot decides
ROUND 3 Earn from him	₹1,080 a year rent; ₹9,225+ a loan	**₹210 a year; ₹2,500 a loan**	✗ Paytm, 5.1× more a year

We can win round one; round two is open; Paytm wins round three. Each saver brings us little, so the agent's pay decides whether the business works.

Sources: tables/scn_retention.csv, tables/story_paytm.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

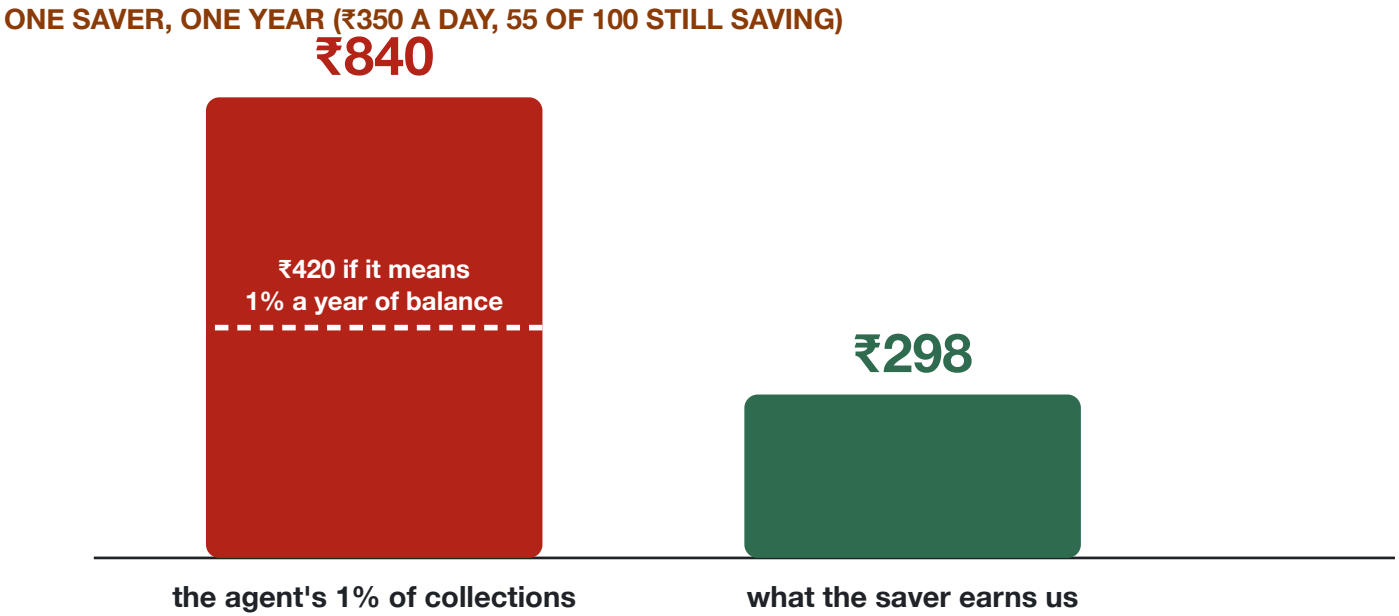
On the proposed pay — ₹20,000 a month plus 1% of every rupee he collects — one agent loses ₹15.97–24.72 lakh over three years, and the more savers stay, the more he loses.



Every saver we keep makes the loss bigger — the opposite of a business built on keeping savers.

Sources: tables/scn_combined.csv, tables/scn_retention.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

The reason: 1% of what he collects costs ₹840 a saver a year, while a saver brings us about ₹298 — almost three times more going out than coming in (₹840 ÷ ₹298 = 2.8).



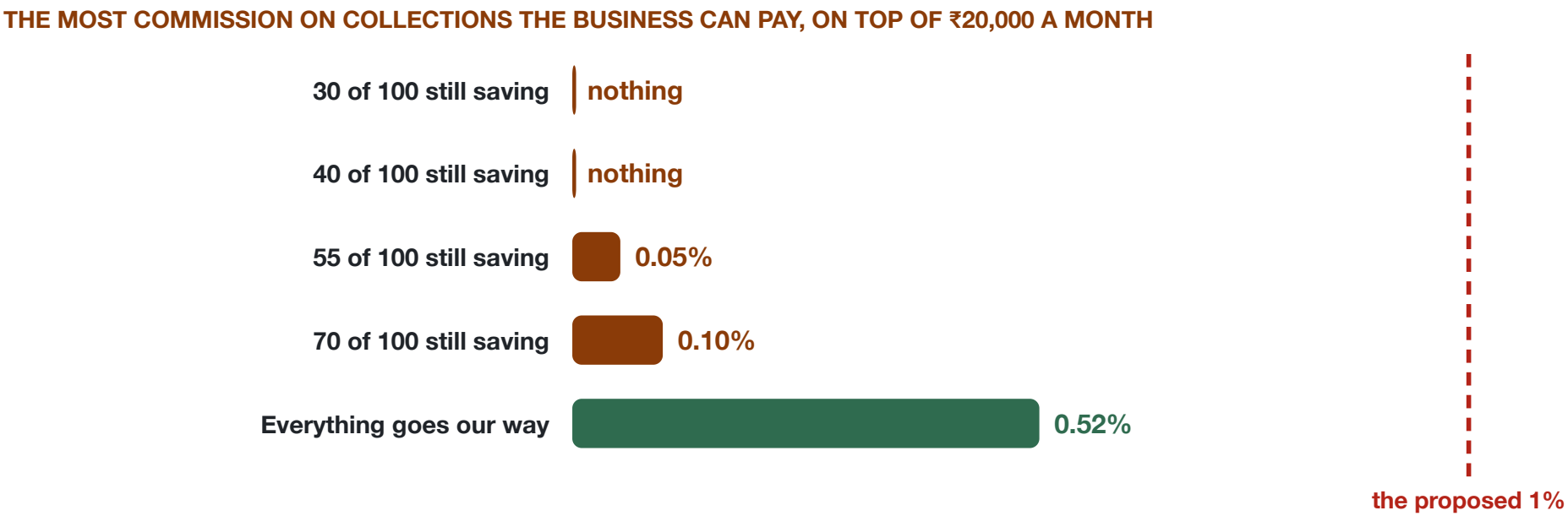
2.8×

more going out than coming in

> **Arvinder's bank pays its agents a share of collections, but the bank keeps the deposit; we do not — our saver's money sits in a fund in his own name and earns us only a small fund commission.**

Sources: tables/scn_customer.csv, tables/scn_retention.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

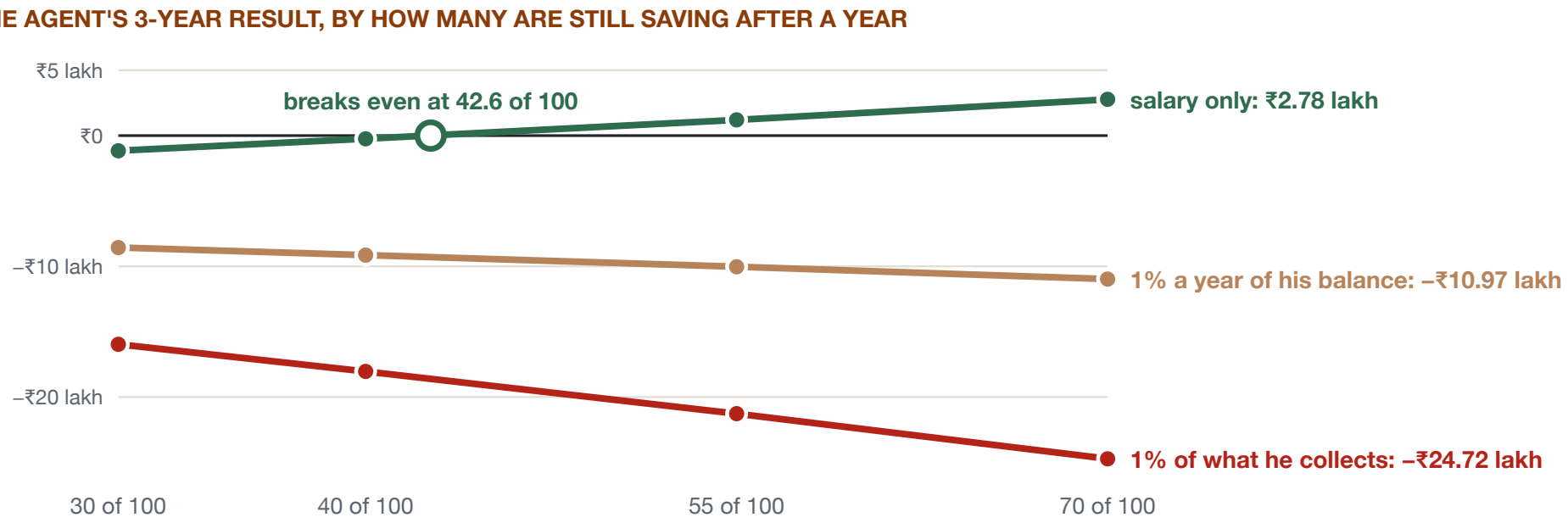
So the most the business can add to the salary is about ₹1 for every ₹1,000 he collects, and only in the best case — a tenth of the 1% proposed; in the bear case it can add nothing.



Better retention raises what we can afford, but never to 1% — not even if everything goes our way.

Sources: tables/scn_breakeven.csv, tables/scn_combined.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

On salary alone, retention decides: he breaks even at 42.6 of 100 still saving after a year. The bear case (30–40) loses up to ₹1.16 lakh; the best case (70, from one interview) makes ₹2.78 lakh.

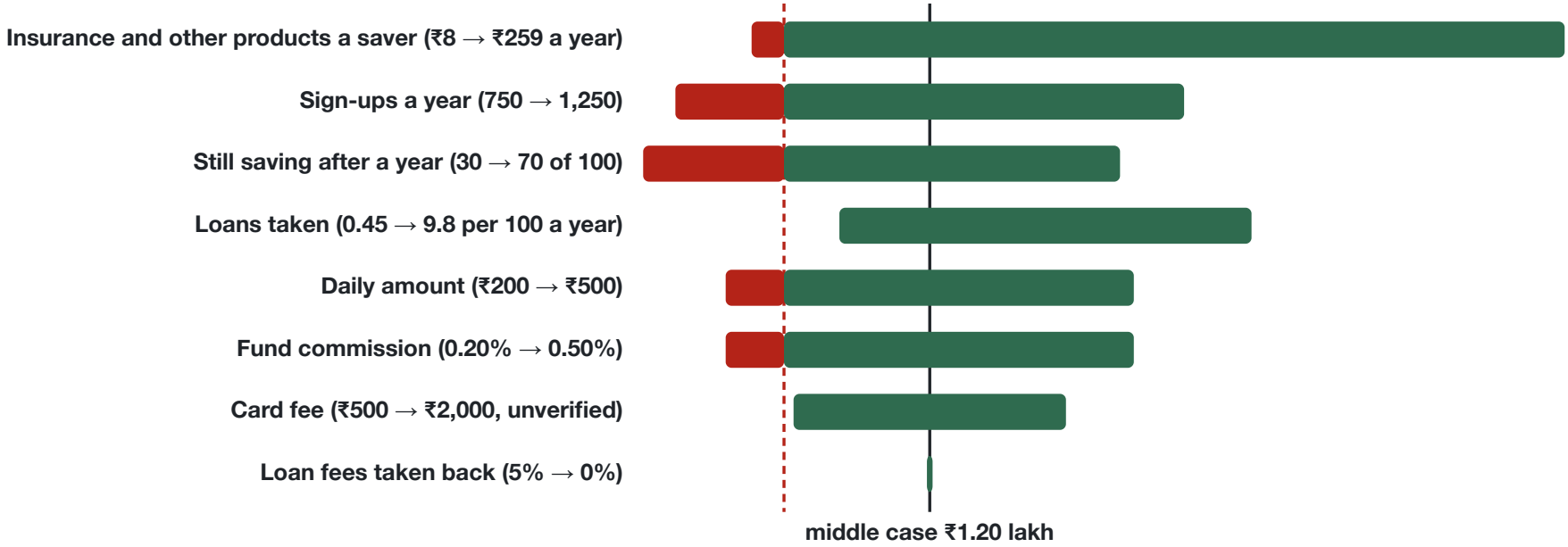


Better retention makes both 1% pays worse and salary pay better. With a Paytm-like 4.5% loan fee the break-even falls to 26.9 of 100, inside the bear case (appendix A11).

Sources: tables/scn_retention.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

Two assumptions swing the result even more than retention — how much insurance and other products each saver buys, and how many savers one agent signs up — and five can each, alone, turn the middle case into a loss.

ONE AGENT, 3 YEARS, SALARY ONLY: EACH ASSUMPTION MOVED ALONE FROM THE MIDDLE CASE



Next come loans taken, the daily amount and the fund commission; the card fee (unverified) matters less and fees taken back hardly at all. The biggest swing is our weakest number: its take-up rates are our judgment, and its high end is every product at its best at once.

Sources: tables/scn_inputs.csv, tables/scn_oneway_salary.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

So we test it with one salaried agent for 12 months: it passes if he signs up about 1,000 savers a year, more than half still save after a year, and each buys about ₹63 a year of other products.

Months 1–3 (1) — **From month 7** (2) — **Month 12** (3)

Sign-ups

- ✓ pass — about 83 a month (1,000 a year)
- ✗ stop — below 62 a month: 3 years lose ₹89,712

Insurance and other products

- ✓ pass — about ₹63 a saver a year
- ✗ stop — at ₹8: 3 years lose ₹26,771

Still saving after a year

- ✓ pass — 55 or more of 100 (+₹1,20,384 over 3 years)
- ✗ stop — below 43 of 100: he does not pay for himself

Run it on salary — the 1% commission fails on paper before it starts — so the first question is whether a salaried agent still signs up 1,000 a year; also get a partner to confirm the card fee.

Sources: tables/scn_inputs.csv, tables/scn_oneway_salary.csv, tables/scn_retention.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

Every input in the stress test, with its low, middle and high value and where each comes from.

INPUT	LOW	MIDDLE	HIGH	WHERE IT COMES FROM
Still saving after 12 months	30% / 40% (bear)	55% (our middle)	70% (best, janta-like)	operator, 16 Oct 2026; steady monthly drop-off
Agent pay		Rs 20,000 a month + 1% of savings		operator, 16 Oct 2026
Daily amount a saver puts in	₹200	₹350	₹500	rupees a day per saver: Arvinder's customers ₹200-500 (interview, 15 Oct 2026)
Sign-ups per agent a year	750	1,000	1,250	sign-ups per agent a year: operator 1,000; +/-25% is our range
Fund commission a year, on the balance	0.20%	0.35%	0.50%	fund commission a year on the balance (XB-04)
Insurance and other products, a saver a year	₹8	₹63	₹259	other products, rupees per saver a year (XO-39)
Card fee (5% of sign-ups get a card)	₹500	₹1,250	₹2,000	rupees per card, 5% of sign-ups (BM-08, unverified)
Loans per proven saver a year	0.45%	2.50%	9.80%	loans per proven saver a year: eligible x apply x approved (tables/agent3_funnel_inputs.csv)
Loan fees taken back	5%	2.50%	0%	share of loan fees taken back (XL-13)

The middle values are our best estimates; only the retention range and the pay come from you.

Sources: tables/scn_inputs.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

A2 / A12 APPENDIX · YEAR BY YEAR

Year by year for one agent: under both 1% pays the loss grows every year; on salary even the 30-in-100 case is just above zero by year 3.

PAY, STILL SAVING AFTER A YEAR	YEAR 1	YEAR 2	YEAR 3	3 YEARS
1% of collections, 30 of 100	–₹3,96,232	–₹5,74,093	–₹6,26,249	–₹15,96,574
1% of collections, 40 of 100	–₹4,17,605	–₹6,48,026	–₹7,38,408	–₹18,04,039
1% of collections, 55 of 100	–₹4,44,977	–₹7,56,703	–₹9,25,380	–₹21,27,061
1% of collections, 70 of 100	–₹4,68,783	–₹8,65,078	–₹11,38,614	–₹24,72,475
1% a year of balance, 30 of 100	–₹2,47,900	–₹2,97,447	–₹3,11,109	–₹8,56,456
1% a year of balance, 40 of 100	–₹2,54,459	–₹3,18,112	–₹3,41,787	–₹9,14,358
1% a year of balance, 55 of 100	–₹2,62,801	–₹3,48,177	–₹3,92,360	–₹10,03,339
1% a year of balance, 70 of 100	–₹2,70,011	–₹3,77,899	–₹4,49,550	–₹10,97,460
salary only, 30 of 100	–₹99,569	–₹20,801	₹4,031	–₹1,16,338
salary only, 40 of 100	–₹91,313	₹11,802	₹54,834	–₹24,677
salary only, 55 of 100	–₹80,626	₹60,350	₹1,40,659	₹1,20,384
salary only, 70 of 100	–₹71,239	₹1,09,280	₹2,39,514	₹2,77,556

On salary year 1 always loses, because signing up costs come before savings build; the question is how fast the book grows into profit.

Sources: tables/scn_retention.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

A3 / A12 APPENDIX · PER SAVER WON

Per saver won, over his own first three years: on salary every street saver at least earns back his cost; on the proposed pay each one loses 2.3–4.4 times what an app's saver does.

PER SAVER WON, HIS FIRST 3 YEARS	COST TO WIN	EARNS US	COMMISSION	NET
Online, an app	₹499	₹219	₹0	–₹280
Street, salary only, 30 of 100	₹240	₹249	₹0	₹9
Street, salary only, 40 of 100	₹240	₹305	₹0	₹65
Street, salary only, 55 of 100	₹240	₹405	₹0	₹165
Street, salary only, 70 of 100	₹240	₹527	₹0	₹287
Street, 1% of collections, 30 of 100	₹240	₹249	₹645	–₹636
Street, 1% of collections, 40 of 100	₹240	₹305	₹826	–₹760
Street, 1% of collections, 55 of 100	₹240	₹405	₹1,142	–₹977
Street, 1% of collections, 70 of 100	₹240	₹527	₹1,524	–₹1,238

This view counts each sign-up's first 36 months, so it is kinder than one agent's three calendar years, where late sign-ups are cut off. Its online line uses a steady drop-off to 24 in 100, so it differs slightly from page 1.

Sources: tables/scn_customer.csv, tables/scn_retention.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

On the proposed pay, everything that grows the book grows the loss: a bigger daily amount or more sign-ups make it worse.

INPUT (PROPOSED PAY, 55 OF 100)	LOW	HIGH	3 YEARS AT LOW	3 YEARS AT HIGH
Pay: salary only (no commission)			₹1,20,384	₹1,20,384
Daily amount a saver puts in	₹200	₹500	–₹13,32,429	–₹29,21,693
Pay: 1% a year of balance			–₹10,03,339	–₹10,03,339
Still saving after a year	30%	70%	–₹15,96,574	–₹24,72,475
Sign-ups per agent a year	750	1,250	–₹17,75,295	–₹24,78,826
Insurance and other products, a saver a year	₹8	₹259	–₹22,74,215	–₹16,02,657
Loans per proven saver a year	0.45%	9.80%	–₹22,01,699	–₹18,61,275
Fund commission a year, on the balance	0.20%	0.50%	–₹22,95,619	–₹19,58,502
Card fee (5% of sign-ups get a card)	₹500	₹2,000	–₹22,39,561	–₹20,14,561
Loan fees taken back	5%	0%	–₹21,29,395	–₹21,24,727

The pay rule is the single biggest assumption in the model — bigger than any market input.

Sources: tables/scn_oneway.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

All five combined cases on both pays: on salary the range runs from –₹5.84 lakh (all bad) to +₹25.58 lakh (all good); on the proposed pay even 'all good' loses ₹23.52 lakh.

CASE	SALARY ONLY: 3 YEARS	COVERED	PROPOSED PAY: 3 YEARS	COVERED
All bad	–₹5,83,674	19%	–₹12,18,061	10%
Bear retention, rest middle	–₹24,677	97%	–₹18,04,039	28%
Middle	₹1,20,384	117%	–₹21,27,061	28%
Best retention, rest middle	₹2,77,556	139%	–₹24,72,475	29%
All good	₹25,58,483	455%	–₹23,52,287	58%

'All good' puts every input at its high end at once, including other products at ₹259, which is itself every product at its best — a corner, not a forecast.

Sources: tables/scn_combined.csv, tables/scn_combined_salary.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

A6 / A12 APPENDIX · IF '1% OF SAVINGS' MEANS 1% OF HIS BALANCE

Read as 1% a year of his balance, the loss is roughly halved but stays at ₹8.56–10.97 lakh over three years, and the most we can afford is 0.11–0.20% a year.

STILL SAVING AFTER A YEAR	3 YEARS ON 1% OF BALANCE	COVERED	MOST WE CAN AFFORD ON BALANCE
30 of 100	–₹8,56,456	41%	0.000% a year
40 of 100	–₹9,14,358	43%	0.000% a year
55 of 100	–₹10,03,339	46%	0.107% a year
70 of 100	–₹10,97,460	48%	0.202% a year

Either reading of '1% of savings' costs more than a saver earns us; this one just loses more slowly.

Sources: tables/scn_breakeven.csv, tables/scn_retention.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

A7 / A12 APPENDIX · WHERE A SAVER'S INCOME COMES FROM

Nearly half of what savers earn us is the fund commission; cards and other products bring about a fifth each, and loans about a tenth.

WHERE ONE AGENT'S INCOME COMES FROM (55 OF 100, SALARY ONLY)	3 YEARS	SHARE
Fund commission	₹3,93,303	46.8%
Credit cards (fee unverified)	₹1,87,500	22.3%
Insurance and other products	₹1,68,558	20.1%
Loan fees	₹91,022	10.8%
Total, 3 years	**₹8,40,384**	**100%**

The money comes mostly from his savings, not his loans — so keeping him saving matters more than lending to him.

Sources: tables/scn_retention.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

A8 / A12 APPENDIX · PAYTM IN DETAIL

Paytm against an app and our street agent, line by line — its ₹5,000 cost to win is an upper bound that includes servicing.

	An app	Paytm: the closest to us	Our street agent
How he is won	ads, installs, sign-up offers	a field force at the shop	**an agent at the counter**
Cost to win him	₹499	up to ~₹5,000 per device added	**₹400**
What keeps him	push notifications	a box on the counter: device shops held through the 2024 shock (1.06 → 1.07 crore)	**the visit every 2–3 days**
What he pays every year	nothing	₹1,080 in device rent (₹90 a month)	**nothing; the fund and products pay us ₹210**
What one loan earns	a referral fee	₹9,225–₹10,250 (4.5–5% of ₹2,05,000)	**₹2,500 (1% of ₹2.5 lakh)**
How it collects	the borrower's bank account	from the shop's daily payout: losses 4.5–5%	**the saver's bank account (UPI AutoPay)**

✓ **Our edge:** we win him for ₹400, not up to ₹5,000 (12.5× less).

× **Our gap:** Paytm earns 5.1× more a year from each customer, and 3.7–4.1× more per loan.

Our edge is the cheap win and the visit; our gap is what each customer pays us. The old '12.5× cheaper' used the ₹400 agent cost and is replaced by ₹5,000 ÷ ₹240.

Sources: tables/story_paytm.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv. A8 still shows the old ₹400 street cost to win; this deck's is ₹240.

A9 / A12 APPENDIX · THE ONLINE COST TO WIN

How we estimate the online cost to win: three published signals, scaled up 10% for shopkeepers because no payments firm publishes its own.

HOW AN APP WINS A DAILY SAVER, AND WHAT IT COSTS



₹2,067

for each saver still saving after a year

and he earns back only ₹243
in his first 3 years: the app never recovers what it paid

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

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₹796–1,374 a customer, with 83% coming free

Finance-app installs
₹100–300 each

Jar, Stable Money
₹249 a saver, only if half of sign-ups save

SBI's ₹250 daily SIP
lost 35.6% of FY26's new savers within the year

At the bottom of the range each saver kept costs ₹770 (₹186 ÷ 0.2415) — about the street's bear case (₹800).

Sources: tables/distributions.csv, tables/story_unit.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

A10 / A12 APPENDIX · THE ONE INTERVIEW

The one interview behind the best case — and two places where our plan asks far more of an agent than his job does today.

QUESTION	ARVINDER'S ANSWER (15 OCT 2026)
Book size	200 to 400 customers
Customer types	Shopkeepers (most), street vendors, homemakers, daily-wage workers, drivers, salaried, small workshop owners
Daily deposit	Rs 200 to 500
Monthly income of a typical customer	Rs 20,000 to 40,000
Have a smartphone (of 10)	9 or 10
Have UPI (of 10)	9 or 10
Of every Rs 100 collected, in cash	90 or more
Why cash despite UPI	Habit
What customers asked about last month	A loan, insurance
What customers need most	A loan
How long most customers have saved with him	Over 5 years
New customers last month / closed last month	6 to 10 / 6 to 10
Pay	Fixed salary Rs 15,000-25,000; under 2% on collections
Operator's note after the call	Bank employees. They collect cash and have trust
Agent	Arvinder Singh, Bareilly, co-operative bank (PNB named), over 10 years, consented to notes

He is a co-operative bank employee of 10+ years with a mature book, so his 72 in 100 may flatter what fresh sign-ups will do.

Sources: research/interview_arvinder_2026-10-15.csv, tables/scn_inputs.csv, tables/scn_retention.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

A11 / A12 APPENDIX · WHAT THE STRESS TEST LEAVES OUT

What the stress test leaves out, now partly run: a Paytm-like 4.5% loan fee lowers the break-even to 26.9 of 100 still saving; tele-sales, the AI agent and the office are still not counted.

STILL SAVING AFTER A YEAR	SALARY, 1% LOAN FEE	COVERED	SALARY, PAYTM-LIKE 4.5% FEE	COVERED	MUST PAY BY UPI, YEAR 3
30 of 100	–₹1,16,338	84%	₹45,021	106%	0%
40 of 100	–₹24,677	97%	₹1,95,762	127%	0%
55 of 100	₹1,20,384	117%	₹4,38,962	161%	26%
70 of 100	₹2,77,556	139%	₹7,06,474	198%	45%

Break-even: 42.6 of 100 still saving at a 1% loan fee; 26.9 of 100 at a Paytm-like 4.5% fee, earned by collecting instalments on the visit and sharing first losses (Paytm earns 4.5–5% a loan, SE-05; RBI caps first-loss cover at 5%, SE-04). Still not in any number: tele-sales, the AI agent, the office, KYC.

The Paytm-like fee is now run under salary pay; the support costs still need modelling before the pilot budget is set.

Sources: research/story_evidence.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.

The flat ₹4 lakh agent is replaced by ₹20,000 a month plus a commission, so the cost to win falls from ₹400 to ₹240 and the old payback months no longer apply.

	LAST DECK	THIS DECK
Agent cost	₹4 lakh a year, flat	₹20,000 a month (+1% of collections tested)
Cost to win a saver	₹400	₹240
Retention	one case: 72 of 100 (janta book)	30, 40, 55, 70 of 100
Payback	month 22 (14 with a Paytm-like fee)	replaced by the agent's 3-year result on each pay

Pages 7–11 replace the old 'one kept saver' and 'one agent's book' pages, which rested on the ₹4 lakh agent.

Sources: tables/scn_retention.csv, tables/story_unit.csv. Built by model/scenarios.py and model/build_stress_deck.py; story text from story/storyline_2026-10-16.csv.